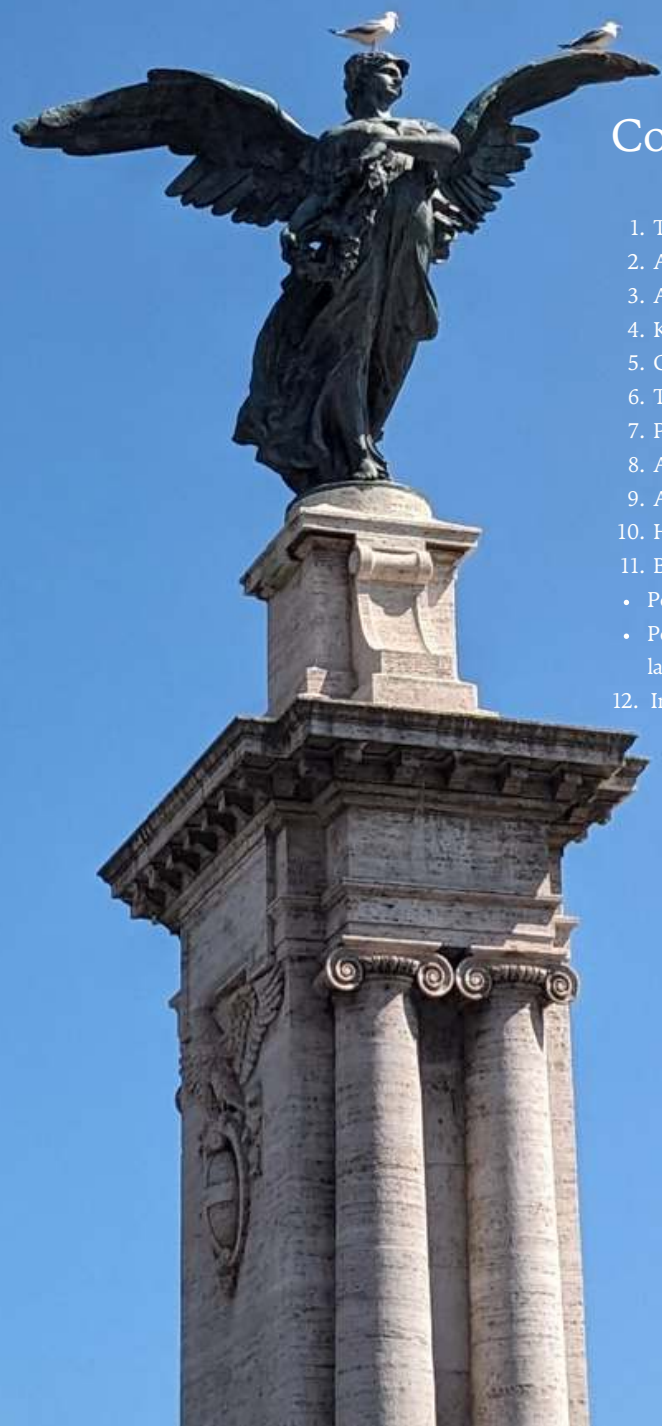


Stumbling Upon History

Abstractions of a
month in Rome
by Ardhra



August, 2023



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That which calls to me

The Church Next Door

It took a few months of emotional and physical hassle, and plenty of uncertainty, for me to get to Rome. The University seemed to say, in usual fashion, we've given you a seat in the program, but getting yourself past international restrictions and other logistical constraints, is on you. And it doesn't matter as much to us, whether you make it or not. Past all that, when I did get to Rome, it was this dome that hammered it into my jetlagged head. I was in Europe! (?)

The cobblestone streets, or the Italian driver whom I couldn't understand but could laugh with while he showed us ancient landmarks, or the wacky driving etiquette that took me straight home to Chennai, or the oleanders



The dome of the Basilica as seen
from the UWRC

that I've not seen in the US, should have all been as concrete an indicator of our arrival. Having put away our luggage and registered ourselves in, fully stopping after many hours of motion, to pass by a window with this sight as though it was no big deal, was what drove it home. In Rome, people probably just walk right past these domes and not give it a second look.

This church, mystically enough, called out to me. I met the church, or stumbled upon it on day one when I got out to get a SIM card for immediate empowerment (in the era of eSIMs). That's the fun part about Rome, take a turn and you could stumble upon history, some magnificent feat of architecture just there, unassumingly in the midst of manic modernity. The Trevi Fountain, for instance, juts out of a building in the middle of a dense residential-looking area. The waters are so opaline and fresh in the hot sun, carrying the wishes of millions of people in its might. Getting out for a walk, taking steps with my own feet gives me a semblance of control in strange places. Reeling from living in a new place with new aspects to my identity, a temporary relocation to Rome was unimaginably crazy. Yet it was all happening, and I had to take it all in. Too many gelatos, too little time. That was most of our mottos.

The church, called the Basilica di Sant'Andrea della valle, made in the 1600s, is a gilded marvel on the inside of a seemingly ordinary church (by Roman standards).



Basilica di Sant' Andrea della
valle

One of the only churches I found to have mirrors on tables for us to not careen our necks while trying to take in the details of the ceiling. I barely have any of the details in my mind, except noticing the play of light inside it. The light from one particular window, the one through which the sun was shining seemed as though God was looking down at us. The bright golden-yellow light was other-worldly. I started noticing how churches have a way of using sunlight in this manner as the sun makes its errand around a dome during a day. Churches at night are more or less large buildings.

I'm often looking for spiritual moments and in my culture, we have this belief that you are not separate from God(s). You are one half of the supreme power, which is a lot of autonomy. The idea is that you have and are Godliness, and hold the agency to do what is required of us in this lifetime - our karma. Karma is action, akin to purpose, and not limited to consequence.





The light certainly felt like a strong and wonderful presence that couldn't possibly hold grudges over my sins from past lives or this one.

The dome also quickly became a lighthouse for our temporary home. Very close to some of our apartments, if we tried walking in its direction, the rest of the way would be navigable despite how labyrinthine Rome is. The city is quite understandable, it's epicenters seem clear. One can see the Vittorio Emanuele monument from the Piazza del Popolo and like me, imagine they've figured the city out. Until, like with much else in life, you zoom out a little. The narrow streets, lived and ageing, that are bubbles of ignorance. I expect even the oldest residents to be a little unsure of what they might stumble upon.

One day, I found this mysterious pattern made by reflected sunlight on one of the walls of the Basilica. I know that you will find it hard to not be skeptical, but the friend I was with can attest to the fact that it's almost impossible to find what was creating that.

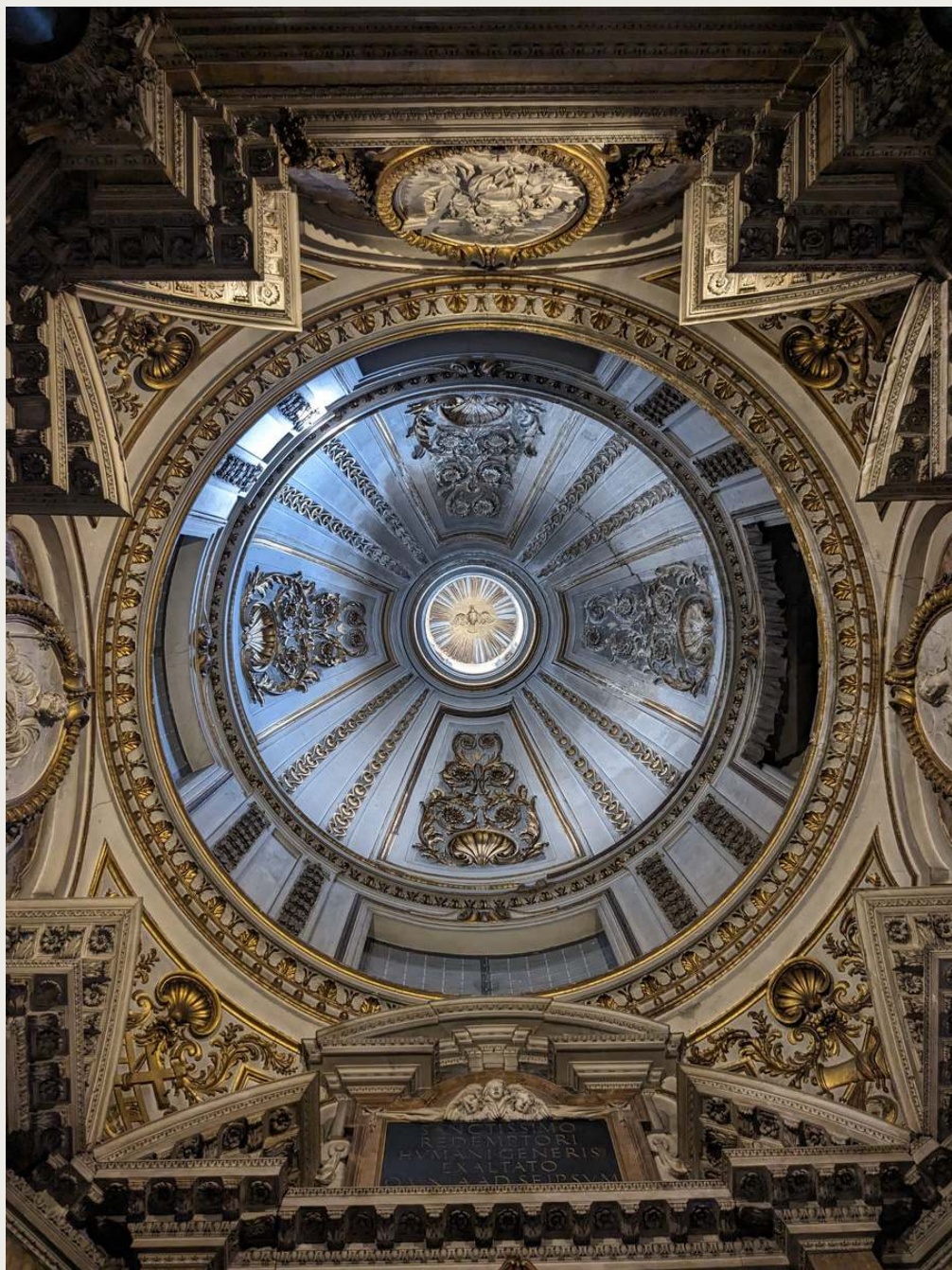


1st sighting vs 2nd sighting



The sun is on the same side as these patterns, so it's not direct sunlight.

Faith, it seems, is a lot about accepting the mystery, kind of an agnostic certainty that we will never really know. And so I don't know if that's an 'ankh', or an infinity separated by something, or a Jesus fish. But, it's the Godly light that put some of my qualms to rest while in Rome.



The holy dove watches much of the
ruckus from above, but also seems to
remind that we've got some God in us too

A blessing
&
a curse

I bless this world of the
heartbroken to be healed
by the full moon.

I curse the pessimists to
be hit by a lightning of
hope, or a feather.



An epitaph

To my Thatha (grandfather)

I hope that you are still around, gently guiding Amma as you always do, and maybe spare a minute on me as I trot around the globe. I know you do when a breeze of safety hits me in uncertain waters, as this. Adventure is full exposure of the jugular to dissonance. Just living with that cut, hopefully not too deep, but uncomfortably warm from the oozing blood.

I hope you're not upset that I don't buy the best groceries in town, or walk long distances as you did. Maybe in walking so much, I am trying to catch up with you. Ammammai and I are going to be slow no matter what. The roads are as unfamiliar as always, but the flowers and the skies are smiling, particularly when I'm talking to everything and comes by a well-timed breeze, or a dewdrop on my cheek. Do you nudge them to do that sometimes?

As I continue to walk, although I tire out really quickly, I think of you for the strength you passed on, and the anger, of course. For the way you raised your daughter, and the way that has led her to raise hers. I knew you for less than my life so far, and somehow I might be learning more about you as I walk with you, Thatha.





Not Keats's quill. One from a
store in Florence.

Unquestioned Answers

Keats's Quill

The pen has been a great friend, and I imagine
Keats felt the same.

'How's the pen?'

Someone asks, and I don't know.

Well.

As well as it can write,

Well.

As well as I can ever be.

Well. For

As long as I can conjure magic.

'Vibes, that's all anything is anymore,'

A friend tells me, and I agree.

The pen sets the tone,

Based on what I know and remember.

Messages from a different realm,

The Source, as I deem it.

The Source of everything, all truth,

All beauty, the goal of life on earth.

What life is complete without enduring beauty,

Of one kind or another.

Beauty of the kind that a pen like you

Must try to draw upon.



You must miss the fingers that led you,
Dipped you in ink,
And let you dance on the paper?
Poetry in motion, your dance.

Is it difficult having just a shadow of
your power?
All that is left of the odes that he wrote,
Just a nib, not even the feathers,
Not even the veins that held and
dribbled the ink.

If I were you, I'd continue to dance.
Scratches on parched parchment
Until ink assuages, quenches,
The yearning to catch beauty.

A view of the Spanish steps from
John Keats's house in Rome where he
lived for 5 months before dying of TB



Auguries

Charting Your Luck

A witch's instructions to charting your luck through shagun/augury

I apologise if I sound like an angry woman.

Or a gull squawking. I might be a bit angry with you.

I'm mad alright, but the inner happenings of my head
Are the business of the omens, the shagun.

You don't know how to use any of it, do you?
Of course not. No one listens to an old hag.

Your day, whichever is the most important, will be good.
Start seven minutes late, no more or less,
To wherever you need to be, maybe a bus.



Sit by a window and let the sun bless your wings.
Then, you will start to see the signs—
The numbers you love, the names you love.

Could be the area code, or the miles ahead of you
Before living the dream you're awaiting, or the price of petrol.

If you're lucky, you'll be visiting Etruscan tombs.
Look for a friendly-looking lizard, black with shiny green spots,
He will welcome you aboard.

Aboard where?! Where do you think you have come?
Hush now! Things can go either way from here.
It's time for caution.

***At the top of the page is a "Pillayar suzhi." It's an ode to Ganesha, the Hindu God who is the remover of obstacles. It's a symbol used to invoke auspiciousness to the document in question.**

If there's a black cat,
Be sure not to let any of its hair get in your mouth!
You could get crazy! Well, crazier.

The tombs are for singing,
For echoing the lives of the celebrated dead.
But they're also for us to see where we are headed.

If the first one you head into holds water,
Watch out for some snakes in your inner circle.
I had told Caesar the same thing, but who listens to an old witch?

In other tombs, there are little tent-shaped rocks.
If you find them, rest assured, you're going home.
Just bide the time before getting there.

If the one you find has bugs that don't bite,
You will have used up a lot of luck,
Make sure to give a little back to those around.
I take gold or cash, I'm not picky.

But if you don't go into one of those,
And yet find a harmless bug up your sleeve,
The cicadas are cheering for you!
Do you hear them?

In the Etruscan city of the dead,
"Necropolis" in Cerveteri, Italy



But if you don't go into one of those,
And yet find a harmless bug up your sleeve,
The cicadas are cheering for you!
Do you hear them?

They're luring rain in.
But, for you, the rain clouds will move aside,
And the sun will shine again.
Grab one of the cicadas! Quick!



Fold it into your notebook.

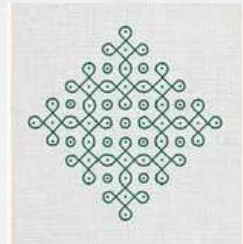
I'll take a wing or two,
Maybe grab a few of them, you never know.
Rainy days call for dried cicadas.

If birds fly and dance around
when you take your camera out.
Luck isn't on your side, you are luck.
Don't go about telling people this.



Luck only lasts in modesty.
Oh and do not step on a dung beetle.
It's here to tell you not to go that way.
What did I say? Follow the butterfly. Always.

The white one is dependable, the black one's moody.
If you find an orange one, don't try to take it home,
She's trying to take you there.
But, where are you headed?



If you don't know that,
How do you expect me to help?
Lucky for you, I can get the crows to swoop in.
Sometimes, people find answers in the dust they leave behind.



Quietly breathe in sync with the breeze,
That's how you invite the good.
Now that we've charted your course for luck,
What do you plan on doing with it?

The patterns here are called 'kolam' in Tamil. They are drawn
at dawn in front of homes as a way of inviting auspiciousness.

Visual poetry

The Vatican Spectacle

Symbols to remember oppression, invasion, continued subtle oppressions, racism, sexism, misappropriation of other cultures, privilege, authenticity, and life

The clock may have ticked in
your hands,
But soon, it won't.



Visual poetry

Postcards from the Roman Forum

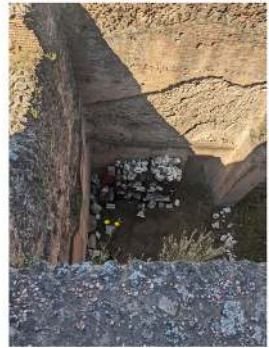
A blend of current reality and historical fiction



A last wall standing welcomes you to
Augustus's house,
Or asks that you stay out



A church that's a forlorn temple



Fragments that will never be whole because they
cannot be reconstructed



Spouting through remnants of a garden fountain that cannot
touch water anymore, like an ancestor who cannot guide the
living.



The sole demon lifts the Goddess of Muses up. The rest of
the Gods stand on inanimate pedestals.

She holds the wrath of the river until the pyre vapourises all
the water, and what's left are tears.



They pray that the river be of the exact level, speed, and
minerality the city needs, in the way they ask of me to temper
my emotions, words, and actions

A manifesto for waiting

Waiting in prayer,
Outside hospital wards,
Loud, unfettered,
Desperation leaves no room
for embarrassment, or such external qualms.

Waiting under a tree,
On a hot day,
For a gentle breeze,
For focus to ebb back
And get through the page to the next.

Waiting for the clock to tick,
To wash away the details
Pain is less searing then.
Tick,
Tick, don't talk, just keep ticking please!



An exhibit at the National Gallery of
Modern and Contemporary Art, Rome

Waiting to hear back,
From a homie who hasn't been home,
The house is astray,
Life feels the same,
The clock needs new batteries.

Waiting for the gifts you want to give,
The flights are long,
Window seats are your best friends
Everything feels auspicious,
They have to be.

Waiting for a smile to come by,
Usually takes a few tears first,
But then your face will work again,
And that'll do for today.
Good job.

A riddle

I'm of 15 or 20 pleats
On my skirt that gravity may not tug at.

Botches of white on potassium,
Or ivory, or indigo dry.

A sun of yellow
Rises from the core of my being.

So do Gods and their consorts,
And history and ice.

A bird I may not be,
But of plumage
Sometimes brighter than your mind.

I've been here since time immemorial,
The myths sing of me,
And beauty bows over.

I wonder what it is about me,
All I see below is my murk-laden children
Who play in still waters.

We flourish in sunshine,
Because the night is for dreams.

If you know not me yet,
Pray, inquire of your deepest truth.



Hadrian's last words

I'm ready now, so don't weep for my absence. Remember who you are and where you come from. I am, as my roots come to take me back home into earth.

The water around me cools my heart while my mind races in the fear of what lies ahead.

But, lord fire will come to put it all to rest. This minute seems to last longer than it did years ago, and for that growth, I'm joyful.

The clouds above seem gay, floating towards me taken by the high winds. Thank you for your patience, I have been able to see so many skies.

Rome: A Living History

BRAND ROMA



A Reality Check

My humorous take on Rome as a living history, is that of a brand-building project under the premise that Rome is a brand that needs work.

Scenario: Romulus and Remus have approached my branding agency for help to build their new city, and well, Remus is quickly unavailable, and there's not a lot of budget to begin with. Under the circumstances, I propose to the client what the brand needs and how we can build it. Cut to a few centuries of success later, the client is back with a rebranding request, as you'll see in the presentation.

The overarching theme is of reality - understanding, evaluating, and redefining Rome's reality.

At first, the reality that Rome is not a city and just a brick wall, is no obstacle. Then, reality becomes a battlefield of religion. In the present-day, reality is merely a distraction that we escape by traveling to Rome.

This includes two of my poems from the class pitches.

IN 16 SHOTS

To me, Rome has been about the pastel coloured buildings, high-contrast flowers in pink, blue waters of the fountains, the food (sometimes needing a bit more flavour for my liking), the funky knockers, some graffiti, and most importantly the tiny cars I can't get over. It was a pleasure to let this city find a place in my heart.



